

Spain: Mass border breach will likely give the far-right a one-off boost

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Quick take

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

Tens of thousands of undocumented migrants, mostly minors, breached the Spain-Morocco border in the Spanish North African enclave of Ceuta yesterday, after overwhelming border security and physical barriers. Spain has deployed army units to the area in response to shore up border security and backstop the overstretched police force.

Our Take

The mass breach was likely caused by a confluence of factors. A recent constitutional court ruling made expedited repatriation more difficult. Social media helped draw in large crowds. The breach may have also been facilitated, or at least not actively impeded, by Moroccan authorities: a tried and tested pressure tactic.

Lax enforcement on the Moroccan side was a key driver of the last mass breach in 2021. It pushed Spain to side with Morocco in its long-running dispute with Algeria over Western Sahara. This incident could be partly a response to a recent thawing in relations between Madrid and Algiers, after the Spanish Prime Minister travelled to Algeria last week for the first time since 2020 and agreed to a further increase in gas deliveries from the country.

The breach will likely lead to a one-off boost in support for Vox. The far-right Vox party is best-placed to capitalise. While it will likely give Vox a boost in opinion polls, with elections at least six months away, it is unlikely to have a major bearing on the outcome, assuming it remains an isolated incident. It reinforces expectations that elections next year will produce a conservative government led by the center-right Popular Party (PP) with Vox as junior partner.

Undocumented migrants cannot easily travel onward to mainland Spain. Madrid will likely step up expedited repatriations. Talk of limiting free movement within the EU in response is mostly for effect and any restrictions would likely be short-lived. Other major European elections in 2027 are also far

enough off that the breach is unlikely to have a major bearing unless it is repeated.

A conservative government would tighten immigration policy. A PP-Vox government is likely to tighten immigration policies to a degree, such as by avoiding new amnesties, tightening residency requirements, and restricting access to welfare. US-style mass deportations are not on the cards. This would put downward pressure on net immigration over time, now running at over 600,000 per year and a key factor underpinning high economic growth rates. The vast majority of net inflows are driven by Spanish-speaking immigrants from Latin America, who travel to Spain legally and later take advantage of regular amnesty bills.

Longer-lasting pressure on the border could prove more consequential. Spain may ease off on the push to restore ties with Algeria. However, this is unlikely to jeopardize Algeria's role as a major and growing gas supplier to Spain. Spain will also step up border enforcement going forward, possibly including a permanent army deployment to backstop police. Still, if pressure on the border does not ease as a result, leading to recurring breaches that keep the issue in the headlines into 2027, this could prove more consequential.

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